

Multiple rounds of discussions took place to assess the requirements, and to address these, we proposed various solutions. Ultimately, we zeroed in on Linux-based applications as the way forward to build the required solution,” says Rajesh Kumar S, COO, Focuz Infotech. The group required a web-based ERP solution for data and transactions management. A retail management ERP solution named ‘Techfocuz Enterpriser’ was developed to address all these requirements.

The features offered by the TechFocuz Enterpriser include the generation of automated balance sheets as well as MIS and DSS (management information system and decision support system) reports. The ERP system provides any information required on the Group’s operations at the click of a button. The application is powered by PostgreSQL and Java, running on SUSE Linux Enterprise edition on IBM Power systems.

Techfocuz Enterpriser also has an inbuilt analytics capability to enable data analysis. This helps the group’s management to take informed decisions. “Although the application was tailor-made to address the requirements of the Focuz Group, seeing its success, Focuz Infotech is planning to promote it as a product soon,” says Kumar.

A robust application, riding on PostgreSQL

Techfocuz Enterpriser (TE) is a very large, integrated solution, and addresses the entire operations of the Rs 2,500 million Focuz Group. TE’s robustness can be assessed from the operational complexity that it helps the Focuz Group to manage to perfection. Some of the key benefits that the application offers are listed below.

The Focus Group deals with 18 companies and 2,50,000 lakh products; the database holds records of around 1 crore stock items, while 400 people work on the new ERP system concurrently. The application captures and manages information related to the complete cycle of products—from procurement to sales realisation. For instance, Focus Automobiles uses the system to keep track of bulk spare parts from the moment a transaction begins (including vehicle sales management, service management, computer retail sales management, and any other process involved) till it ends in a sale.

“The application’s humongous database-related requirements are adequately met by the PostgreSQL database management system, which runs in a high-



Rajesh Kumar S, COO,
Focuz Infotech

availability mode on IBM’s Power servers, over a 64-bit Linux operating system,” says Kumar.

Serving 5,000 customers on a daily basis would have been a difficult task to accomplish, if not for the existing infrastructure, says Kumar. The solution is quite scalable, and allows integration with devices such as bar code and biometric systems, radio frequency identification systems, picture archiving and communication systems.

Cost savings

Since the ERP is Web-based and manages the entire data in a consolidated way, there are almost no manual operations required in the electronic data processing department. This has reduced the cost of manpower in many departments, including accounts. Apart from this, the group’s 800 workstations and servers now run on Linux, and this has saved the organisation millions of rupees by eliminating the licence costs for 800 Microsoft operating systems, virus scanners and MS Office applications. “I can easily say that adopting Techfocuz Enterpriser has saved the Focuz Group at least Rs 3 crore,” claims Kumar.

PostgreSQL!

Apart from the cost benefit, there are many advantages of using an open source solution like the PostgreSQL database-management system. “Over-deployment is considered by some proprietary database vendors as their main licence compliance problem, but PostgreSQL gives you immunity from over-deployment,” Kumar reveals. “With PostgreSQL, nobody can sue you for breaking licensing agreements, as there are no associated licensing costs for the software. It turns out as a profitable model when there is wide-scale deployment. There is no possibility of being audited for licence compliance at any stage. PostgreSQL gives you the flexibility to do concept research and trial deployments without including additional licensing costs, and even provides better support than proprietary vendors. In addition to the benefit of strong support, we have a vibrant community of PostgreSQL professionals and enthusiasts that an organisation’s staff can draw upon, and even contribute to,” he adds.

PostgreSQL is available for almost every brand of UNIX (34 platforms, with the latest stable release), and Windows compatibility is available via the Cygwin framework. Native Windows compatibility is also available with version 8.0 and above. Kumar adds, “We use a multiple-row data-storage strategy called MVCC to make PostgreSQL